



Qualification Programme Examination Panelist's Report

Module 4 – Business Management (June 2023 Session)

(The main purpose of the following report is to summarise candidates' common weaknesses and make recommendations to help future candidates improve their performance in the examination.)

(I) Section A – Multiple Choice Questions

General Comments

The multiple-choice questions tested the candidates' fundamental knowledge of business management in various aspects, including marketing, strategic management, international business, control, finance, organizational behaviours, and service concepts. In addition, there were several questions that required candidates to apply a deeper understanding of the concepts and knowledge to different aspects of business management.

Generally, candidates had good performance related to common conceptual questions, but performed unsatisfactorily on the questions that required candidates to answer some concepts which are not common.

Specific Comments

Candidates showed weaknesses in the following areas:

- Business and organisation
- Production and operations management
- Control systems and risks
- International business
- Service management

(II) Section B – Written Questions

General Comments

The questions in this section aimed at testing candidates on their conceptual understanding as well as their ability to apply their knowledge to specific company situations. It is very important that the candidates respond to the questions in relation to the specific concepts and knowledge required under the different scenarios given in the questions.

In general, candidates performed well on those questions related to some common concepts and theories, as well as straightforward questions. In such cases candidates



performed very satisfactorily, providing detailed answers that were relevant to the scenarios.

However, some candidates could not answer the questions about topics unrelated to their daily work. This may have been due to inadequate knowledge of the relevant concepts or insufficient preparation for the examination.

Specific Comments

Question 1(a) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to identify and explain one decision that a finance manager needs to make. However, many candidates were unable to explain the specific concepts related to the decisions that a finance manager makes all the time. Many candidates mixed up with short-term financing.

Candidates may not have clear differentiations between different sub-topics in a specific topic area.

Question 1(b) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to state and explain two short-term finances appropriate for the case company. Generally, many candidates had average performance on this question and many of them were able to score more than half of the total marks of this question.

Question 2(a) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to state the type of organization the case company belongs to as well as its mission. The majority of candidates were able to answer this question and score full marks. This may be due to the sufficient information provided in the case scenario. Moreover, the type of organization in the scenario is well-known to the candidates and the term is well-known from candidates' daily lives.

Question 2(b) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to identify and describe one source of funding that the case company can obtain. Similarly, this was a fairly easy question and more than half of the candidates scored half or full marks.

Question 2(c) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to describe and illustrate the characteristics of effective control systems that the company should pay attention to. This particular concept is not easy to the candidates and many of them performed poorly on this question.

The topic of control is always difficult for candidates and candidates really need to spend

time preparing and remembering relevant points and concepts under this topic. If the candidates do not have sufficient time to prepare for this topic, they will be unable to provide satisfactory answers for this type of question.

Question 3(a) – 4 Marks

This question required candidates to state and describe the interview questions under structured interview and illustrate with examples. Not many candidates were able to provide accurate answers for this question and around half of the candidates scored very low marks. Candidates were not able to use the terminology related to the concept and the examples provided were not conceptually accurate.

This may be due to insufficient knowledge of this topic. This question was related to their personal experience and thus, they were able to provide examples without correctly understanding the concepts.

Question 3(b) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to identify and explain the types of monetary rewards apart from base compensation. Half of the candidates did not perform well on this question and many candidates got a very low mark. Candidates were not clear about the concept related to this topic. Although this question was common and dealt with an issue that candidates are familiar with from their own jobs, candidates were not clear about the differentiation between different types of monetary rewards.

Question 4 – 10 Marks

This question required candidates to state and describe the new product development process and illustrate using the case company. Many candidates did not provide accurate answers and thus many scored very low marks.

The product development process is always difficult for candidates because candidates need to thoroughly prepare and remember the process before the examination.

Question 5(a) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to state and explain the ways that the company can enter a country. Around half of the candidates scored almost full marks for this question. Compared to previous years in which candidates were asked about this topic, the candidates' performance was satisfactory.

Candidates might have read the comments and recommendations before preparing the examination and did some preparation.

Question 5(b) – 6 Marks

This question required candidates to identify and describe the issues faced by the company when entering the country for international trade. More than half of the



candidates scored almost full marks, which demonstrates good performance for this question.

The candidates were likely able to find relevant information from the case scenario to help them answer this question.

Question 5(c) – 8 Marks

This question required candidates to state and explain the elements of marketing mix for the company. Candidates' performance on this question was spread and some of the candidates performed unsatisfactorily but some of them got high marks.

Surprisingly, this topic should be easy to the candidates and this should help candidates to get higher marks. However, it may be due to the insufficient understanding of the marketing mix concept.

Question 6(a) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to define service package. Almost no candidate was able to answer this question. Candidates' very unsatisfactory performance is likely due to a lack of familiarity with the concept.

This question was related to service and asked candidates to define, which would pose difficulty to them especially when they did not prepare the examination well.

Question 6(b) – 8 Marks

This question required candidates to state and explain service elements and illustrate with an example. The majority of candidates did not perform satisfactorily on this question. Less than half of the candidates scored half of the total marks of this question.

Similarly, this topic was related to the service concept. Thus, if the candidates did not prepare sufficiently, they were unable to answer this question correctly.

Question 6(c) – 2 Marks

This question required candidates to define SWOT analysis. More than half of the candidates received full marks for this question, indicating an overall high level of performance on this question.

The reason may be due to the simple concept asked in this question. SWOT analysis should be the most fundamental concept that need to be covered in any business disciplines and thus, candidates should be able to answer well.

Question 6(d) – 8 Marks

This question required candidates to identify the SWOT for the case company. Only few candidates did not perform well on this question. This indicates that candidates



performed well for some most fundamental questions, and particularly this question relates to the application of SWOT analysis which must be easy for the candidates as they should have applied this in any business subjects.

(III) Conclusion and Recommendation

Overall, the performance of the candidates was better than before, although some candidates' performance demonstrated insufficient preparation for the examination. Most of the candidates were able to provide answers to the questions and discuss relevant concepts, especially when the concepts were easy or the information and answers could be identified from the case scenario. However, when candidates were asked about concepts other than finance, or encountered topics which required a lot of reading and preparation before the examination, candidates were not able to provide sufficient elaboration, for example, service concept, new product development process, control systems, etc. Some suggestions are provided below to assist candidates to better prepare for the examination.

First of all, candidates are advised to read the questions carefully as some of the candidates might have misunderstood or confused with other concepts based on the question. For example, one of the questions in this set of paper required candidates to identify the decision made by the finance manager but most candidates instead provided answers related to short-term finances.

Moreover, there may be some related concepts under the same topic. Similar to the above suggestion, candidates are advised to differentiate different sub-topics and try to understand the outlines and main theme of each sub-topic.

Secondly, candidates are advised to prepare and sufficiently study the materials. This module encompasses a large scope of different areas of study and thus, if candidates are only familiar with some areas which may be related to finance or their jobs, they will not be able to complete the examination satisfactorily. It is important to prepare and study the materials well before the examination in order to clearly understand the various concepts.

Finally, candidates are advised to elaborate the points with relevant examples based on the concepts asked. Some candidates were not able to apply the relevant information from the scenario or illustrate. Thus, candidates should try not only understand the concepts but also apply the relevant concepts.